CORHC-0004 — Shannon Morgan Oral History, April 01, 2009

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
00:01
Hello, this is April 1st, 2009. My name is Carrie Gutierrez. I'm the Assistant Curator of Collections at the First Division Museum at Cantigny.

00:10
I am interviewing Shannon Morgan at the McCormick Research Center at the First Division Museum at Cantigny, located in Wheaton, Illinois. Okay. The first question I want to ask you, Shannon, is when did you enter the Army?

Shannon Morgan
00:26
Uh November of 2001.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
00:28
Okay.

Shannon Morgan
00:29
And why? Uh for the college money, my family's not very rich, so um basically I wanted uh a chance to further my education.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
00:38
Okay

Shannon Morgan
00:39
And plus 9-11, I didn't want that happening again.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
00:43
Okay. So it was very much in response to the Exactly.

Shannon Morgan
00:46
I joined pretty much immediately afterwards.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
00:48
Wow.

Shannon Morgan
00:49
So

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
00:51
So tell me about joining the 1st Infantry Division.

Shannon Morgan
00:55
It was exciting. First of all, I went to BASIC and Fort Jackson, South Carolina. Then I went on to my MOS School for Track Vehicle Mechanic in Aberdeen Proving Grounds, Maryland. And then to my first duty station at Fort Riley, Kansas.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
01:10
Okay. How were you received into your unit?

Shannon Morgan
01:15
Um well I was the only tracked vehicle mechanic at Fort Riley, female anyways, so I was in a 37-man all pl all-man platoon, all males Uh it was definitely different. Uh at first they didn't know what to do because they didn't want some sissy female working with them. But it took about five minutes for them to realize that I was gonna be able to hang.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
01:36
Okay. Okay. So you they They accepted you quickly?

Shannon Morgan
01:41
Okay. Definitely.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
01:42
Okay. What when you you know at first you said it was a little it was a little tough.

Shannon Morgan
01:47
Yeah, I was walking in with my platoon sergeant who come and picked me up at receiving uh and I heard the guys talking in the motor pole and they're like, Oh no, here comes a girl, we're not gonna be able to cuss and do our dick and fart jokes or whatever and so uh it took about five minutes for me to opening my mouth and having a conversation. They were like, oh she's cool. So nothing to worry about.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)

02:07
Okay. Well that's good. It's good What kind of training did you receive?

Shannon Morgan
02:12
Um, I received the MOS school for tracked vehicle mechanic, which was about 12 weeks.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
02:17
Okay. What is what does um that include?

Shannon Morgan
02:21
I work on all the tanks. Anything that has track on it, um I worked on that.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
02:25
Okay, so any repairs, any repairs, maintenance.

Shannon Morgan
02:28
Maintenance, driving them, fixing them, mm-hmm, all of that.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
02:31
Okay. Did you did you have any experience with that before or they kind of taught you everything?

Shannon Morgan
02:36
Yeah. Um not with tanks or anything like that, but I had uh mechanical knowledge because my father uh growing up I was tomboy of course and he would show me how to fix something once and if I didn't pay attention then the next time I had to pay for it to fix it.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
02:51
Okay.

Shannon Morgan
02:52
So I had a little bit of a mechanical incline knowledge to that.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
02:55
Yeah Okay. So what were your those were I think you kind of pretty much covered then your duties before getting into Team Lioness. Okay. So what were your duties specifically in Team

Lioness?

Shannon Morgan
03:10
Uh we were we were as assigned to um assist the males in searching the Iraqi women because uh it started to portray out where um the males would give the women all of their explosives and their detonators and uh pertinent information they would give it to the women because in Iraq uh American soldier males are not allowed to touch the women.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
03:34
Okay.

Shannon Morgan
03:34
According to their religion.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
03:36
Mm-hmm.

Shannon Morgan
03:37
So that's where they saw the need for us to come in and bring females to search them.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
03:42
I see. So they would give it to the women in thinking that no one would search them so it was safe with them. Exactly.

03:49
Okay. Now in the film I um I believe there was there was some parts. How much was I think there was you you talked about comforting the women.

03:57
Was that a major part of it or was it really just, you know, doing the search?

Shannon Morgan
04:02
Um, it was a little bit of both because once they realized that we were uh women ourselves They started giving up information about telling us where major players were hiding out, uh people we were looking for.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
04:14
Okay.

Shannon Morgan
04:15
And they ended up giving us a lot of intel that the male soldiers would not have been able to re to get

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
04:21
Now did they realize that when they're telling you these things, I mean this is information that you're after? With I mean did they how readily did they give up the information?

Shannon Morgan
04:30
Well, it would have to be when they were away from their husbands and families. So we would pull them into different rooms away from, you know, separate them away from their men and as soon as we did that they'd start talking to us. Uh the women were actually they wanted the war to end and they wanted all the the violence to stop.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
04:47
Okay.

Shannon Morgan
04:48
So That's why they would speak with us.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
04:50
Okay, so they they trusted the lionuses fairly quickly.

Shannon Morgan
04:55
Exactly.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
04:56
What do you think um What do you think how do you think that they perceived you, you know, in their culture seeing women co you know, soldiers in combat. How do you think they react to that?

Shannon Morgan
05:07
I think I think they were in a little bit of admiration almost because the women over there are treated very badly. I mean they're not even allowed to walk side by side next to their husband. When they ride in a car they have to sit in the back seat.

05:19

Mm-hmm. Uh they always have to be three steps behind him. And uh there's usually five of 'em, uh five wives per man, depending on their income.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
05:29
Okay.

Shannon Morgan
05:29
So

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
05:30
Wow.

Shannon Morgan
05:30
I think they w I think they kinda looked up to us almost having in that freedom, so to speak.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
05:36
Yeah. Did did you ever have a conversation with one of them where any of them addressed any of the Wolves women addressed that or anything?

Shannon Morgan
05:42
Um not necessarily. I mean the only the only places um they spoke real um they spoke English really well was like at the schools and things like that and those were teachers who were teaching. Um the schools are separated as well, all females and all males.

05:58
Okay. So, um, most of the time those kind of women didn't really want to talk to us too much. They just wanted us out of their school so they could get back to teaching.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
06:06
Yeah, okay. So when you were taught how to search these women, did you I mean was there anything that was really kind of outstanding or was it a basic search or basically just a basic search like airport security. Okay It's a good way to Yeah. Okay. Um did you so did you feel like your training for, you know, in in theory what you were supposed to do is, you know, your job as a lioness, did you feel it was adequate for what you ran across?

Shannon Morgan
06:37
Not when we started to encom uh to encounter combat, no, because we're not trained to be

infantry soldiers. It's against DOD policy for women to be in frontline ground combat. So we had no experience in that sort of training whatsoever.

06:50
I mean we had basic training, but they don't train you like they do the men that are infantry. So um absolutely not. I don't believe we had enough training whatsoever.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
06:59
Okay Okay. So your your mission, as you understood it as as a lioness, was basically to go in with with the Marines or, you know, and and do these searches. Correct.

07:13
Okay. Okay. What was your first operation as a lioness?

Shannon Morgan
07:18
Oh goodness. My f my yeah. My first one, myself and uh good friend of mine, specialist Stone, was attached to one five Um, which is Army of course.

07:28
Um anyways, uh we had to go out and do a Was it a knock and greet or was the first one a bug hunt? Gosh, so many of 'em. I believe the first one was just a knock and greet.

07:42
We were trying to get out there and get the word out, um, that we're friendly, we're here to win hearts and minds and And basically that's what it consisted of.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
07:51
Okay, okay. The other one that you mentioned, the what hunt. What does that mean?

Shannon Morgan
07:56
Bug hunt was what code words we use when we were looking for specific uh high value targets.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
08:01
Okay, okay. Now is that Ramadi? Okay that we talked that you talked about in the DVD?

Shannon Morgan
08:08
Like the uh the deck of cards. That you guys have probably heard of, um, with high value targets on it.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)

08:15
Okay.

Shannon Morgan
08:15
That's what we did. We went out and arrested these people.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
08:18
Okay. So your first mission it did it go well?

Shannon Morgan
08:21
Absolutely, yeah. It was it was pretty fun. I was scared to death, of course. um in the back of stack teams and uh but it it went really well. I mean it was just basically going in and checking things out and making sure they had no weapons of mass destruction of course and and uh we didn't find anything so

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
08:40
Okay.

Shannon Morgan
08:40
We returned back to base.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
08:41
So after that you felt a little more comfortable?

Shannon Morgan
08:44
Yes. Okay. Yeah, well kind of. And so we got hooked up with the Marines because one five field artillery is still army, so

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
08:54
What would you you know there was a lot in the DVD about, you know, um government policy, et cetera, and you know how what happens in practice in Team Lioness, how it conflicts with that. What would you want to say to government officials ab about being a lioness, the existence of lionesses and the role of women's service in the military as a whole?

Shannon Morgan
09:18
Um, I would say that in the beginning, um even Mr. Donald Rumsfeld himself was denying that we were even doing it. Um So that was kind of a a sharp stick in the eye. But uh anyways, I think

women are capable. Uh faces of war have changed and we're moving ahead and uh I would definitely say to them that if they want us to play infantry, that they should allow us to be infantry. Okay.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
09:47
So there's a lack of knowledge and publicity about what lionesses do. If you were if you were to write the message to the public now, what would you have it say?

Shannon Morgan
09:58
Oh goodness. Um that team line us is Well, just from my own experience, Team Lion S was the first female uh combatant unit, so to speak, if you will. Um, I would I would let the public know that uh women are out there doing the same thing that the m uh male infantry soldiers are doing now.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
10:26
Mm-hmm.

Shannon Morgan
10:27
And uh I don't know, I guess that's it.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
10:31
Okay. You would just want to inform them that it is indeed taking place.

Shannon Morgan
10:35
Exactly. It still continues on to this day.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
10:38
Okay. How prevalent are lionesses? Is it is it just in the first division or Um no actually it's it's army wide from what I understand.

Shannon Morgan
10:48
Um more and more units are using it and actually the Marines are using uh lineasses now out of their own segregations. Okay.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
10:58
Okay. So it's fairly widespread. Do you have any idea how many trained or helped?

Shannon Morgan
11:03
Yeah, I have no idea.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
11:05
Okay. Okay. So you th well, do you think that women should be allowed in direct combat? Why or why not?

Shannon Morgan
11:12
Absolutely. Um there are women that are very capable of doing it. Um I believe that uh You know, we're in a new era.

11:21
We're fighting different kinds of wars. And uh I believe women are just as capable as men these days. And I think uh I think we deserve to be there right side by side.

11:32
They push for all kinds of equality in the Army and we bunk together, we sleep together, we fight together, we train together. So I absolutely believe we deserve to be in direct ground combat.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
11:43
Okay. I mean have those uh expired for that you feel do you feel those have expired for why women were not you know are not allowed allowed to be able to do that.

Shannon Morgan
11:56
Yes, absolutely, yeah. I I think uh I think the chauvinistic side of it has uh started to um go down. I I mean, I don't think that people are quite as quite as chauvinistic as they used to be because, you know, uh this is the twentieth century and and we're moving ahead. Women do a lot more these days than they did back then.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
12:24
Right. Um, who who has helped you the most in dealing with your military experiences and your memories?

Shannon Morgan
12:35
Um, the VA counselors. Uh there was one in particular, her name was Michelle Leva and she was the first person I spoke to when I went to the VA. Um, she was really there for me, her and my uncle.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
12:48
Okay. Okay.

Shannon Morgan
12:49
Because your uncle was the He was a three tour of Vietnam, but yeah, he was the only man left returning from his company.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
12:55
Wow. Okay. But it helps to have family, you know. Yeah. Somebody who's who's always there with you supporting you.

Shannon Morgan
13:02
Exactly.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
13:04
Um At at at the VA what did do you mind me asking? What are some of the things that like how did she help you or

Shannon Morgan
13:13
Um, basically she just let me rant and rave, uh, when probably most psychologists wouldn't let you get that uh crazy. But uh she was always there for me. Um I think she knew when I was scared to talk about things and I think she also knew how to approach it Um she had only dealt with male um uh soldiers for the most part, but it it was it was just so weird because there was a certain comfort level there between us and uh She she just she had my back the whole time.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
13:49
Okay. Did she happen to notice any or communicate to you any difference between you know, you dealing you as a woman dealing with your experiences as opposed to men, she's a little bit of a you know, men are more pent up and they don't open up as much as

Shannon Morgan
14:06
women do and they tend to to wait until it's too late.

Speaker 3
14:10
Mhm.

Shannon Morgan

14:10
I mean there are, you know, a lot of a lot more soldiers that are males that attempt suicide than females. Okay. So, I mean it's like She just knew.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
14:22
Mm-hmm. So do you still talk to her or um no not at this point.

Shannon Morgan
14:28
She switched VAs. Um she's went to a different location and I'm not in contact with her anymore.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
14:35
How long did you spend with her?

Shannon Morgan
14:37
About a year and a half.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
14:38
Wow, okay. And you felt that it did you feel it helped and Um how have your military experiences changed the way you view the world?

Shannon Morgan
14:52
It's made me a a stronger person. I don't take anything for granted anymore, not even toilet paper.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
14:57
Wow.

Shannon Morgan
14:58
But yeah, um it's definitely giving me a new perspective and and it really uh like when fourth of july rolls around you really understand what it's all about.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
15:07
Mm-hmm.

Shannon Morgan
15:08

That freedom doesn't come free.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
15:10
Right. Um, and you say that what what what from your military experiences, um, maybe in particular, is there anything in particular that that causes you to, you know, feel this way?

Shannon Morgan
15:24
I think watching your best friend die. Uh yeah. I think that would have a lot to do with it and the camaraderie that you build being together in a war zone we're actually closer than family members are. And um being over there fighting for this country gives you a real sense of pride.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
15:42
Okay. Absolutely, I can imagine. What advice or thoughts would you share with future women soldiers in combat situations?

Shannon Morgan
15:54
I I would say to them, don't hold back. Uh you can never hesitate. And don't forget that just because you're a female, it doesn't make you incapable of anything.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
16:04
Okay. It's good advice. Yeah. Hmm. Given the work that Team Linus has done, do you think the government will uh change the rules for women in combat and you know if so when do you when do you think this might happen?

Shannon Morgan
16:20
I think I think we're moving to a new stage de with that, definitely. Um we just left Washington D C and uh we spoke to several people who are in charge of making those policies.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
16:32
Mm-hmm.

Shannon Morgan
16:33
So um I believe there's a very good chance that uh Something could change.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
16:38
Okay.

Shannon Morgan
16:39
Definitely. I d I have no idea when it's the government. They do what they want, so but uh They they they really seem to be very interested in it. And um I think they see now that women are capable of this.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
16:53
Okay. Um tell me more about, you know, your trip to Washington, what happened, who did you talk to, what was discussed?

Shannon Morgan
17:00
Um well we met with uh Senator Barbara Davis from California, which she sits on the Congress. Yes, that's it. Yes. She says it's on what?

Speaker 3
17:21
She is the um chairman of the subcommittee on the assignment of uh on military personnel okay right uh my gosh there's so many people we met I can't remember them all but uh

Shannon Morgan
17:36
Yeah um I got to meet uh Blanche Lincoln from Arkansas.

Speaker 3
17:41
Um Senator Blanche Lincoln Senator um The one from Washington, Senator Patty Murray. Okay.

Shannon Morgan
17:49
And Nancy Pelosi gave us the the speaker of the House, right? That were flown um at the Capitol in honor of us.

Speaker 3
17:58
Wow. Chairman Filner.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
18:02
Okay.

Speaker 3
18:03
Okay.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
18:04
No, it's fine. I'm just thinking, I don't think you have a microphone on you. Okay, okay. Yeah.

Shannon Morgan
18:10
I'm sorry, I just can't remember all these people.

Speaker 3
18:12
And Congresswoman Stephanie Hurseth Sandlin from South Dakota and Congresswoman Judy Biggert from Henry. Yep. Um they were all on the panel. Okay. And then we did a press side a press event on the Senate side and there were two women senators who came and Shannon spoke.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
18:30
Okay. Okay Yeah, I was just gonna say um you're you are the director. Well I'll let you introduce yourself.

Speaker 3
18:40
I'm Meg McClagan, the co-director of Director documentary Lion S. Okay.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
18:46
Okay. Thank you. Thank you. So when you went to Washington did all of these people um they all saw the DVD while you while you were there?

Shannon Morgan
18:55
If not had they seen a clip. that they put together a 20-minute clip.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
18:59
I see.

Shannon Morgan
18:59
Okay. So they got to see that if they hadn't seen the DVD, but I'm sure some of them have.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
19:05
Okay. So how did those how did those conversations go? What was discussed? What did they ask you?

Shannon Morgan
19:10
Um they asked us a lot on policy change and what they could do to make it better for women for females in the military. Um Also, uh VA services, uh, because I use the VA a lot now, um, asked us how they could improve that and what they need to do, what steps they should take, things like that nature.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
19:31
Okay Okay. Did you was there anything that you wanted to kind of share about some of the feedback you know you gave to them um in in those meetings, in those conversations, discussions?

Shannon Morgan
19:42
One of my big um quirks was I told them we needed more women therapists because there was a lack of women therapist in the in the VA hospitals Um, the first time I ever went um to a psychologist, if you will. Um, this is after I had received my 100% for being PTSD Um, he basically didn't believe me that I'd ever been in frontline combat. He couldn't fathom the concept of women being in combat.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
20:08
Wow.

Shannon Morgan
20:09
So I there's a there's a great need for women therapist in the VA and that's what I told him.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
20:14
Mm-hmm I'm sorry, you d a few a few seconds ago you just said oh you were when you were This is this is my psychologist that I was assigned to.

Shannon Morgan
20:22
We have teams and things like that.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
20:24
Right. Like they've got to be able to do that.

Shannon Morgan
20:28
100% disabled.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
20:29
I see. Okay. That's okay. Just want to clarify what that meant.

Shannon Morgan
20:32
Yes, 100% disabled.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
20:34
Okay. What what happened in Washington? Did they um did they record that That whole thing was a little bit more than a little bit of a little bit of a little bit of a little bit of a little bit of a little bit of a little bit of a little bit of a little bit of a little bit of a little bit of a little bit of a little bit of a little bit of a little bit

Shannon Morgan
20:40
They had they had their people with them that wrote down everything, yes.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
20:43
Okay, okay.

Shannon Morgan
20:44
Their assistants or whatnot.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
20:46
I see. Okay. Yeah Um you know, you you you and your uncle talked in the D V D about questioning what you've done and in particular I noticed I keyed on in on the fact that you you use you use the word justice. Um and you also said in the DVD that you can't help dwelling on the memories and and wondering In going over the memories time again, time and again, have you found any any justice and what would make what would make it justified?

Shannon Morgan
21:21
Hmm. I don't think there is justice or more. Um basically I just had to accept the fact we did what we did and we did it for a reason and let go and and live on for the people who didn't make it home.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
21:34
Mm-hmm.

Shannon Morgan
21:35

I guess that's all I can really say about that one.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
21:37
That's a little Yeah.

Shannon Morgan
21:38
Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
21:39
Yeah.

Shannon Morgan
21:39
I might start balling on you.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
21:41
Well, I'm ready. Yeah, now I understand. Okay. Um you know, you you talked in the DVD again about um the Marine Squad that you were with in Ramadi that you you mentioned tapping back that the person from what I uh what I gathered from that is the person In front of you is supposed to tell you, hey, we're moving.

Shannon Morgan
22:04
Right.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
22:04
Okay. And they left you.

Shannon Morgan
22:07
Correct.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
22:07
Whatever I mean, so you said that they didn't tap back But did you ever find out? I know you got back to that unit. What happened?

Shannon Morgan
22:15
As of yesterday I was informed by a female Marine that they use hand signals which there was no hand signals to be used but anywho I'm not gonna argue with her um Being a sawgunner, I

was a two four a two four nine sawgunner, so that means I carried a big machine gun.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
22:31
Right.

Shannon Morgan
22:32
So I covered everybody's asses and butts, I'm sorry, in front of me. Um, so it's important to let the person covering your rear know that you're moving.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
22:41
Right.

Shannon Morgan
22:41
And uh from what I understand from her uh that they have three four man teams that move on their own and they're not used to integrating females which we weren't used to being with males. So I mean there was just a lot of miscommunication, but I think they might have fixed some of that by now.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
23:00
Okay.

Shannon Morgan
23:01
I hope so anyway.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
23:02
Is that was that kind of the, you know, lack of some of the mistraining maybe too?

Shannon Morgan
23:07
Not so much that, it's the difference between the different branches.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
23:10
Okay.

Shannon Morgan
23:10
We all do different things. We all move differently, we all fight differently.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)

23:14
Okay. Yeah, you talked about that in the DVD how there was It just they Marines can operate differently. Exactly.

Shannon Morgan
23:20
So that just they assumed probably They assumed that we had already had that training, the same training our our men received.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
23:26
Okay.

Shannon Morgan
23:27
Which we didn't.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
23:28
Got it Okay. Um as so you said as soon as you set foot in Iraq, you said that you felt like you lost a part of you. I'm sure it's very difficult to put that into words, but you know, when you said that in the DVD, if you can, I was hoping you could just talk a little bit more about that.

Shannon Morgan
23:49
Well, I just feel like uh there's there's a part of a part of everybody that you you never would uh open Pandora's box. So to speak, I guess, there's a part of you you never think that you could you could pull the trigger and and kill someone. I mean, when you have to do a s when you have to do something like that, you you lose a part of yourself You have to just let it go and leave it and move on. It takes it takes a l it takes away part of your soul in my eyes.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
24:21
Okay.

Shannon Morgan
24:22
I don't know how to explain it any better, I'm sorry.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
24:24
That does that does clarify it a little better for me. Okay. Um If you knew then what you know now, having gone through the entire experience Would you still have gone into the army and as I understood it from the DVD, being a lionist was voluntary?

Shannon Morgan

24:46
Correct.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
24:47
And or would you still have volunteered for I wouldn't I would not change a thing.

Shannon Morgan
24:53
I mean it sucks what happened, but it's made me a stronger and better person and I thank God every day for it.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
24:59
Wow Well.

Shannon Morgan
25:00
Yeah. I mean, everybody wishes things like that wouldn't happen. But they do.

25:05
So you accept it and you move on. And it's taught me so much. I know there's not anything left in life that I can't accomplish.

25:11
If you can make it through something like that, then You know, you get your head on straight.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
25:15
Makes a lot of sense, yeah.

Shannon Morgan
25:16
Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
25:18
Um is there anything that you wanted to address, you know, regarding the film itself um, you know, maybe something that because of time or whatever, um, didn't make it into the film that you wanted to, you know, add for the record here or Anything that you wanted to address regarding the film at all?

Shannon Morgan
25:39
No, I think they did a good job. We spent way, way too long filming. No, many, many hours. I I think it's important that uh the women get the recognition they deserve. That's another thing

we talked about in DC also is starting a maybe lioness service ribbon which is something that does not exist. I mean they're still on even claiming us really, but um but a service ribbon for females in combatant service

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
26:08
That's great. So who brought that up? Was it was it you? Was it a lioness from the government?

Shannon Morgan
26:12
No, it was actually a lady from Florida.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
26:15
Okay.

Shannon Morgan
26:16
That is uh prior service. And she has a lot to do with the uh Vietnam veterans of America.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
26:22
Okay.

Shannon Morgan
26:22
And uh she actually brought that up. I mean um The the best we get right now is the combat action badge, the cab. It's kind of like the same thing like a a CIB.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
26:34
Okay.

Shannon Morgan
26:35
An infantry badge that the males receive. So now they're starting to give us cabs. And uh I think, you know, that also comes along with a service ribbon that the men get to wear for the CIB. So I think that was important. Uh the women are out there doing these things and I think they deserve the recognition.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
26:53
Absolutely. And and going back to Washington, did they sound like you know, they're gonna be more proactive absolutely good.

Shannon Morgan

27:01
Absolutely. I think things are gonna move forward pretty fast.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
27:03
Did they discuss how how they're gonna make that happen at all?

Shannon Morgan
27:07
No, not necess not necessarily, but there's a lot of chains they're gonna work it through

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
27:11
Okay.

Shannon Morgan
27:11
We talk to the people the exact people you would need to talk to about that.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
27:17
Exactly. Good. Yes.

27:18
Good. Okay. Um You know, is there anything that I that I didn't ask that I should have?

27:27
You covered it. Have I? Okay.

27:28
So there's nothing that you want to add or anything.

Shannon Morgan
27:30
No, I'm good.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
27:31
Okay. All right. Well I think that that covers basically everything that I was going to talk to you about. So thank you very much, Shannon. I appreciate your time.

Shannon Morgan
27:41
Absolutely.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
27:42

This concludes our interview.